

David G Courtney BSc PhD

Senior Lecturer in Molecular Virology, Queen's University Belfast
UK Ambassador for the European Research Council

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Molecular virologist and RNA biologist. David leads The Courtney Group at Queen's University Belfast, which studies how influenza A virus RNA recruits host machinery to be modified, exported, translated and trafficked, and how those dependencies can be turned into RNA-based therapeutics. He has won over €1.8M in competitive funding as sole PI, sits on BBSRC and European funding panels, and represents the United Kingdom as an Ambassador for the European Research Council.

1,531 citations · h-index 19 · 52 indexed works (OpenAlex, 2026-10-08)

APPOINTMENTS

2025 –	Senior Lecturer in Molecular Virology , Queen's University Belfast, UK
2021 – 2025	Lecturer and ERC Research Fellow , Queen's University Belfast, UK Founded The Courtney Group with an ERC Starting Grant.
2020 – 2021	Postdoctoral Research Fellow in Molecular Virology , Queen's University Belfast, UK High-throughput drug repurposing screens against SARS-CoV-2 in airway epithelial cells.
2019 – 2020	Marie Skłodowska-Curie Postdoctoral Fellow , Institut Pasteur, Paris, France Developed methods to identify the host RNA-binding proteins of influenza A virus RNAs.
2016 – 2019	Marie Skłodowska-Curie Postdoctoral Fellow , Duke University, North Carolina, USA Showed how m6A and m5C RNA modifications regulate influenza A virus, HIV-1 and other viruses.
2010 – 2011	Industrial placement, BioPharm R&D , GlaxoSmithKline, UK Twelve months in molecular expression and cell line development.

EDUCATION

2012 – 2015	PhD, Molecular Biology , Ulster University, UK The development of personalised medicines for corneal dystrophies (siRNA and CRISPR therapeutics).
2008 – 2012	BSc (Hons) Biomedical Sciences with industrial studies, First Class , Ulster University, UK

LEADERSHIP AND SERVICE

2026 –	Entrepreneurial Lead, Innovate UK ICURe Discover programme , Innovate UK, UK Research and Innovation Competitively selected for the UKRI-funded programme that helps researchers test the commercial potential of their research through market discovery.
2025 –	UK Ambassador for the European Research Council , Ambassadors for the ERC network One of 32 ERC grantees chosen to make the case for frontier research to policymakers, the media and the research community.
Current	Vice-Chair, Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions Postdoctoral Fellowships panel , European Commission
2024 –	Member, BBSRC Panel of Experts , UK Research and Innovation
Current	Elected member, Virology Division Committee , Microbiology Society
2024	Chair and organiser, UK ERC Showcase , Queen's University Belfast Flagship event with panels featuring Nobel Laureate Prof Emmanuelle Charpentier and Prof Teresa Lambe OBE.
2023 – 2024	Contributor, US National Academies report “Toward Sequencing and Mapping of RNA Modifications” , US National Academy of Sciences Invited ideation panel delegate (2023) and co-author of a commissioned paper (2024).
2021 – 2024	Grant reviewer , MSCA (reviewer and rapporteur), US National Science Foundation panel, Swiss National Science Foundation, Polish National Science Centre
Current	Module Coordinator, MSc Research Project , Wellcome-Wolfson Institute for Experimental Medicine, Queen's
Current	STEM NI Ambassador , Northern Ireland
2014 –	Fellow of the Winston Churchill Memorial Trust , Churchill Fellowship, UK

GRANTS AND AWARDS

2021 – 2026	ERC Starting Grant: PTFLU, post-transcriptional regulation of influenza A virus RNA , European Research Council · sole PI · grant 948834 €1,568,010 to establish The Courtney Group.
2023 – 2026	MRC research grant: host ATPases in rhinovirus replication , UKRI Medical Research Council · co-investigator · MR/X020371/1 £458,574.
2024 – 2025	Royal Society Partnership Grant , The Royal Society · with Regent House School A research project run with secondary school pupils.
2017 – 2020	Marie Skłodowska-Curie Global Fellowship: IAV-m6A , European Commission · sole PI · Duke University and Institut Pasteur €260,000 to study m6A RNA methylation in influenza A virus replication and pathogenesis.
2015	Postgraduate Student of the Year (John RE Scott Convocation award) , Ulster University
2014 – 2015	Churchill Fellowship , Winston Churchill Memorial Trust €7,600 for research stays in Italy and Denmark.

PATENT APPLICATIONS

2024	Novel compounds for the treatment of viral infections , US patent application 18/550,005
2019	Compositions and methods for enhanced gene expression and viral replication , US patent application 16/091,822 Using m6A-associated cellular machinery to boost transgene expression or viral replication.
2019	Single guide RNA/CRISPR/Cas9 systems, and methods of use thereof , US patent application 16/326,908 Allele-specific CRISPR/Cas9 systems for treating corneal dystrophies.

SELECTED TALKS AND EVENTS

2026	Invited speaker: Building ERC-competitive research , University of Split, Croatia
2024	Event chair: UK ERC Showcase , Queen's University Belfast
2023	Delegate: ideation panel on RNA modification mapping , US National Academy of Sciences
2020	Invited speaker: ANRS International Symposium on RNA Modifications , Institut Cochin, Paris

MENTORING AND LEADERSHIP

- Mentored Dr Hannah Turkington to a competitive three-year BBSRC Postdoctoral Fellowship (2024).
- PhD graduates went straight to postdoctoral posts at the University of Cambridge and the University of Copenhagen.
- MSc graduates have moved into government science roles, including Forensic Science NI.
- EMBO Laboratory Leadership course and UKRI Future Leaders Fellows leadership retreat (2024).

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT AND MEDIA

- Regular expert voice on BBC television and national radio during the COVID-19 pandemic, explaining viral mutation, immune escape and variant surveillance.
- Long-form articles for The Conversation reaching international readers.
- Works with regional health bodies and schools to promote influenza vaccination awareness.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Microbiology Society · American Society for Virology · RNA Society

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS

co-senior author · * co-first author. Full list at davidgcourtney.com/publications and on ORCID.

1. Bonazza S, Turkington HL, Sukumar S, Peate E, Coutts HL, Montgomery JJ, Hawthorn C, Getty EMPE, Touzelet O, Barabas J, Power UF, **Courtney DG** (2026). Myoferlin is a component of late-stage vRNP trafficking vesicles for enveloped RNA viruses. *Nature Communications* 17. Cited 1.
2. Bonazza S, **Courtney DG** (2025). Influenza A virus RNA localisation and the interceding trafficking pathways of the host cell. *PLoS Pathogens* 21(4): e1013090. Cited 10.

3. Bonazza S, Coutts HL, Sukumar S, Turkington HL, **Courtney DG** (2024). Identifying cellular RNA-binding proteins during infection uncovers a role for MKRN2 in influenza mRNA trafficking. *PLoS Pathogens* 20(5): e1012231. Cited 11.
4. Dupont M, Krischuns T, Giai-Gianetto Q, Paisant S, Bonazza S, Brault J, Douché T, Perez-Perri JI, Hentze MW, Cusack S, Matondo M, Isel C, **Courtney DG**, Naffakh N# (2024). The RBPome of influenza A virus mRNA reveals a role for TDP-43 in viral replication. *Nucleic Acids Research*. Cited 18.
5. Coutts LH, **Courtney DG** (2024). Identifying individual pseudouridine (Ψ) sites across transcripts from HIV-1 infected cells. *HIV Protocols. Methods in Molecular Biology*, vol 2807.
6. **Courtney DG**, Tsai K, Bogerd HP, et al. (2019). Epitranscriptomic regulation of HIV-1 gene expression by m5C. *Cell Host & Microbe* 26(2): 217–227. Cited 261.
7. **Courtney DG**, Chalem A, Bogerd HP, et al. (2019). Extensive epitranscriptomic methylation of A and C residues on murine leukemia virus transcripts enhances viral gene expression. *mBio* 10(3): e01209-19. Cited 79.
8. **Courtney DG**, Kennedy EM, Dumm RE, et al. (2017). Epitranscriptomic enhancement of influenza A virus gene expression and replication. *Cell Host & Microbe* 22(3): 377–386. Cited 250.
9. **Courtney DG**, Moore JE, Atkinson SD, et al. (2015). CRISPR/Cas9 DNA cleavage at SNP-derived PAM enables both in vitro and in vivo KRT12 mutation-specific targeting. *Gene Therapy* 23(1): 108–112. Cited 129.
10. **Courtney DG**, Toftgaard Poulsen E, Kennedy S, et al. (2015). Protein composition of TGFBI-R124C- and TGFBI-R555W-associated aggregates suggests multiple mechanisms leading to lattice and granular corneal dystrophy. *Investigative Ophthalmology & Visual Science* 56: 4653–4661. Cited 39.